

TECHNICAL PROPOSAL | RFP 0032026

EY LOGO

Brand-delivery support models for emerging protected areas

A response to Conservation International from EY

Submitted to Conservation International Offeror **[[TO CONFIRM: EY legal entity name and registration number]]**

Engagement partner Michael Harris, Partner, EY Business Consulting, South Africa

Date **[[TO CONFIRM: submission date]]**

Part 1: Technical approach, methodology and work plan

1. Understanding the assignment

Conservation International is not asking for park brands. It is asking how park brands should be built, paid for and kept alive once the money that started them has gone. That distinction governs everything that follows. The assignment is a design and feasibility study on delivery models, explicitly not a branding exercise, and its real test is whether the recommended model still stands in year five without a grant behind it.

Three constraints define the answer space. First, resourcing; the 15 priority areas have neither the budget nor the in-house capacity to run sophisticated brands, which is why aggregation is the premise of the brief rather than one option inside it. Second, jurisdiction; the areas sit across Southern, Eastern and Western Africa under different park authorities, co-management partners and national tourism boards, so any model must cross borders without becoming a rival to the national destination brands it depends on. Third, permanence; CI will fund implementation to start, but the model must eventually find its own money, which turns the central design question from how large the grant should be into who pays, for what and why they keep paying.

One instruction in the terms of reference is easy to read past and hard to satisfy. CI asks that the models be compared against existing efforts so the chosen one fills a gap rather than duplicating work already under way. In Africa that instruction bites. NACSO already links the organisations serving Namibia's 86 registered communal conservancies on a single Event Book monitoring system. The Northern Rangelands Trust already pools governance, security and enterprise support for 43 conservancies. MMWCA already speaks for 24 Mara conservancies, roughly 16,500 landowners and 50 tourism partners, and CI has already worked through it, co-creating the US\$5m Maasai Mara Rescue Fund in 2020 when tourism collapsed. An aggregation layer exists in much of the target geography. A model that ignores it will duplicate it.

2. Where we start

We have already built the Activity One long-list. Ahead of this proposal and at our own cost, our team completed a benchmark scan of 31 brands, networks and mechanisms, sorted into seven archetypes by what the central entity actually does, from shared services at one end to curated commercial collectives at the other. Each is profiled on scale and offer, funding, governance and read-across for CI, then rated against nine criteria drawn from CI's own design aims. The scan covers both initiatives CI names, Africa's Eden Tourism and Boundless Southern Africa, alongside KAZA's 'Rivers of Life', the conservancy associations, the site and enterprise standards, the commercial collections and the revenue engines. Annex F reproduces the archetype map and the rating matrix.

That work changes the arithmetic of 12 weeks. A conventional bid spends weeks one to five finding out who is out there. We spend them verifying published figures against primary sources, running the 13 deep-dives the scan has already identified and interviewing the secretariats that publish nothing at all. It also fixes the structure: CI's nine model-elaboration headings become the template every deep-dive is written to, and the rating matrix becomes the scoring frame for the options, so evidence carries straight from Activity One into Activity Two without re-cutting.

What the head start buys CI. Interview requests go out in week one rather than week four. That matters because Boundless Southern Africa, Africa's Eden Tourism, The Long Run and Preferred Hotel Group publish neither fees nor outcomes, and a cold approach to a regional secretariat takes three to four weeks to land. The unpublished commercial terms get eleven weeks to surface instead of six.

3. Approach and method

Activity One: situational analysis and best practice. We verify and deepen the scan rather than rebuild it. Every figure is re-checked against its primary source and graded on three levels, being verified with the organisation, published primary, or secondary report, and each number then carries its grade and its date in the report. Nothing below the top two grades is allowed to drive the base case of any financial model. Thirteen deep-dives follow, eight as case studies with two of them clustered and five as light-touch checks, each written to CI's nine model-design headings. We then map what already serves CI's 15 areas, name the gaps and name the failure patterns as plainly as the successes. The European Charter network fell from 164 protected areas in 20 countries to 91 in 13; Alpine Pearls fell from about 24 villages to 18; LHW dropped its paid consumer tier in 2021; the Commission redesigned EDEN after its 2019 evaluation. Why donor-seeded networks contract is as instructive as why LHW has lasted since 1928. The output is a verified evidence base and a short set of principles for sustainable protected-area branding.

Activity Two: option design and evaluation. Each option is built by setting three switches the benchmarks expose; first, who belongs and who pays, since park authorities are the obvious members but the weakest payers. Second, how it crosses borders, whether through one regional secretariat, national operators, mutual recognition of national schemes or a cross-border legal vehicle. Third, how it sits with the national destination brand, whether owned by the tourism board, structured as a co-brand hub or independent. Four configurations are built against archetype anchors and screened with CI in week 6, carrying at least three forward with a reserve. Each carried option is then elaborated under all nine CI headings, with a ten-year model behind it: cost to serve built bottom-up from benchmark unit economics, and a revenue stack assembled from the revenue-engine modules. Options are scored on the same nine-criterion matrix used for the benchmarks, against published evidence rather than preference, with the scoring shown so CI can dispute it and the weighting CI's to set. We publish the two or three assumptions that would flip the result.

Activity Three: next steps. We set out the implementation path for the preferred model, the further research and stakeholder sensitisation required, and draft the Terms of Reference for the design assignment that follows.

Interviews and the appetite test. The assignment is desk-based and every session runs virtually. We target 16 interviews with 12 as the floor, prioritising the organisations that publish nothing: the Boundless Southern Africa secretariat on 18 years of cost and trade adoption, Africa's Eden Tourism on tiers and fees, the KAZA Secretariat on brand hub adoption and UniVisa uptake, NRT, NACSO and MMWCA on cost per conservancy, and The Long Run on fee levels. On the build, host or borrow question we approach Preferred Hotel Group and SLH on what hosting a Keystone collection would cost. Two virtual sessions after the week 10 draft test appetite against a structured instrument asking what would have to be true for each stakeholder to join, fund or pay, with a written instrument for those who cannot attend. Every comment enters an adaptation log with a stated disposition.

4. Where we expect to land, and why we say so now

These are starting hypotheses, not answers. We set them out so CI can see exactly where we begin and hold us to changing our minds. We expect at least one to be discarded and the recommended model to be a hybrid. A bidder with no starting position has nothing for CI to argue with.

Hypothesis	What the centre does	Who pays	Anchored in
The Shared Studio	Brand toolkit, studio and data spine the areas draw down on, delivered through the associations that already serve them	CI and Keystone donors first, then association subscriptions and per-unit production charges	NPS Harpers Ferry Center; NACSO; NRT; MMWCA
The Keystone Mark	Tiered standard certifying areas, plus a mark licensed to the businesses and products around them, run through national operators	Areas pay assessment and revalidation; certified businesses pay licence fees	Blue Flag; UNESCO Global Geoparks; Slovenia Green; Fair Trade Tourism

Hypothesis	What the centre does	Who pays	Anchored in
The Co-Brand Hub	Thematic routes and ready-made co-brandable product handed to national tourism boards for their own campaigns	Tourism boards and regional bodies, from budgets they already spend; development finance for the build	World Heritage Journeys; KAZA 'Rivers of Life'; Signature Experiences of Australia
The Keystone Collection	Curated collection of lodges and experiences sold through an existing platform's distribution and loyalty infrastructure	Member lodges and operators, through fees and commissions, with a licence fee back to the parks	Beyond Green; SLH Considerate Collection; National Geographic Unique Lodges; LHW

Revenue engines such as a multi-park pass on the SANParks Wild Card pattern, a match facility on the Brand USA pattern, an imagery licence on the Lion's Share pattern and a consumer membership tier are modelled as modules any option can carry, because that is how they behave in the evidence.

5. Work plan and deliverables

The plan holds the four contractual dates and leaves two clear weeks for CI and stakeholder comment between the week 10 draft and the week 12 final.

Weeks	Activity	Work	Deliverable	What CI provides
1-2	Inception	Kick-off, confirm the 15 priority areas, agree interview list, scope and evaluation criteria, issue interview requests	Inception report (week 2)	Priority-area list, stakeholder contacts, kick-off attendance
3-5	One	Deep-dives against the nine headings; primary interviews; best-practice synthesis and design principles	Draft situational analysis and best practice assessment (week 5)	Introductions to named secretariats
6-7	One / Two	CI comment on the draft; option architecture; financial sustainability modelling for each option	Option architecture note	Comments on the week 5 draft
8-9	Two	Full elaboration of each option to the nine headings; stakeholder pros and cons; scoring against CI design aims	Draft option set for internal review	-
10	Two	Recommendation and expected results; presentation to CI and nominated stakeholders	Draft report and presentation on brand delivery models (week 10)	Stakeholder convening, presentation attendance
11	Two / Three	Adapt the preferred model on feedback; implementation path; draft Terms of Reference	-	Consolidated comments by end of week 11
12	Three	Final report combining all elements	Final report (week 12)	Acceptance

Deliverables are submitted in English, in editable format and as PDF, with a slide presentation for deliverable 3. The assignment is desk-based and no travel is assumed. Interviews and the stakeholder presentation are conducted virtually.

Part 2: Management, key personnel and staffing

6. Team and management

The engagement is led by Michael Harris, Partner, EY Business Consulting, South Africa, who holds accountability for quality, reviews every deliverable before it reaches CI, and is CI's escalation point for the duration. Day-to-day delivery runs through an engagement manager who owns the plan, the interview programme and the client relationship. Below that the team is deliberately small, because a desk-based assignment of this size rewards continuity of thinking over headcount.

Role	On this assignment	Named individual
Engagement partner	Direction, quality review of every deliverable, CI escalation, stakeholder presentation	Michael Harris, Partner, EY Business Consulting, South Africa
Engagement manager	Delivery, work plan, interview programme, drafting lead across all three activities	[[TO CONFIRM: named manager, grade and CV]]
Senior consultant, business models and finance	Financial sustainability modelling for each option, cash-flow and funding-need analysis, budget architecture	[[TO CONFIRM: named senior consultant, financial modelling and business planning, CV]]
Consultant, research and analysis	Deep-dive research, interview support, evidence base and source control	[[TO CONFIRM: named consultant, CV]]
Subject-matter adviser, destination branding	Brand architecture, destination brand alignment, review of the option set	[[TO CONFIRM: named destination branding adviser; EY-employed or consortium partner]]
Subject-matter adviser, conservation and protected-area tourism	Protected-area context, conservation-led design, community and co-management perspectives	[[TO CONFIRM: named conservation tourism adviser; EY-employed or consortium partner]]

CVs are at Annex A. Effort by role is set out in the separate Cost Proposal.

7. Quality and risk

Every deliverable is reviewed by the engagement partner before it reaches CI, and every figure carries its source, its date and its verification grade. Five delivery risks matter on an assignment of this shape, and each carries a mitigation built into the plan rather than bolted on.

Risk	Mitigation
Interviewees do not respond inside a 12-week window	Requests issued in week 1, not week 3; the existing desk scan means no deep-dive depends on a single interview landing
Commercial platforms decline to disclose fee terms	Option economics modelled on ranges with the assumption stated, as the benchmark scan already does; no recommendation rests on an undisclosed number
The 15 priority areas are confirmed late	Inception proceeds on the archetype logic, which is area-agnostic; area-specific fit is applied in weeks 8 to 9
CI comment cycles compress the final two weeks	Consolidated comment deadline agreed at inception for end of week 11; scope of change at that point limited to the preferred model
Stakeholder appetite diverges from the evidence	The week 10 presentation is a decision point, not a report-out; divergence is surfaced there and reconciled in week 11

Part 3: Corporate capabilities, experience and past performance

8. Corporate capabilities

[[TO CONFIRM: EY corporate capability statement, 200 to 250 words, covering the EY Business Consulting practice in Africa, the relevant service lines (strategy, business modelling, sustainability and development advisory) and headcount. To be supplied by the EY bid team.]]

The RFP sets eight minimum skills for all offerors. Annex C maps EY's evidence against each. Two warrant comment here. Destination branding and protected-area conservation experience are the two where a mainstream consulting credential is least likely to satisfy a conservation organisation on its own, and the RFP expressly permits a consortium or partnership. We will name a specialist partner for either rather than stretch a general credential to cover it. [[TO CONFIRM: outcome of the capability review against the eight skills, and the consortium decision. Owner: Michael Harris.]]

9. Relevant assignments and samples of work

[[TO CONFIRM: five to eight assignments from the last five years, each with client, year, value, scope and outcome, of which at least three from the last three years carry a sample of the work delivered that has been cleared for release. Annex C. Criteria 1.2 and 2.2 together carry 35 of the 70 technical points and are scored on this material. Client consent and release clearance are the critical path and should start before anything else in this response is drafted.]]

One sample is offered now, and it is not a client engagement. The benchmark scan described at section 2 is EY's own pre-bid research on precisely this question, produced at EY's cost, covering 31 benchmarks across seven archetypes including both initiatives CI names. We offer it as evidence of capability and of head start rather than as a service delivered to a client, and an extract is at Annex F.

10. Geographical reach and familiarity

We argue this in three layers, and each is falsifiable. First, network: EY member firms in the countries holding CI's priority areas, stated country by country with entity, office and consulting headcount. **[[TO CONFIRM: country-by-country EY footprint, once CI releases the list of 15 areas.]]** Second, delivery: assignments actually run in Southern, Eastern and Western Africa in the last five years, named by country and year, because presence without delivery reads as a map rather than as experience.

[[TO CONFIRM: Africa assignment list by country and year.]]

Third, subject familiarity. The evidence base for this assignment is itself Southern and Eastern African. The two initiatives CI names are a SADC-hosted secretariat and a Botswana-domiciled association. The conservancy associations that matter are Kenyan and Namibian. The clearest African precedent for CI's revenue-engine ideas, the SANParks Wild Card, pools more than 80 parks across five South African and Eswatini agencies. A South Africa-led team sits at the centre of gravity of that material rather than at its edge.

We should be plain about Western Africa. The RFP describes the 15 areas as being in Southern and Eastern Africa in one sentence and across Southern, Eastern and Western Africa in the next, and the published record on regional destination branding is thin in Western Africa for everyone working on this question. Francophone and Lusophone reach needs named people rather than a network claim, and we will close that at inception once CI confirms the list.

11. Client references

Three client references are provided at Annex B, each with the organisation, a named contact, the assignment referenced and written consent to be contacted. **[[TO CONFIRM: three referees, their contact details and their consent. Owner: EY bid team. Consent takes lead time and should be sought before the other annexes are drafted.]]**

12. Submission and declarations

This technical proposal is submitted with a separate Cost Proposal as a distinct PDF, as the RFP requires. The signed Offeror Representation of Transparency, Integrity and Social Responsibility accompanies this submission.

[[TO CONFIRM: CI to issue the Representation form; EY signatory and date to be confirmed.]]

Annex E maps every requirement in RFP 0032026 to the place in this response where it is met.

Offeror **[[TO CONFIRM: EY legal entity, registered address and registration number]]**

Authorised signatory **[[TO CONFIRM: name, title and signature]]**

Validity This proposal remains valid for **[[TO CONFIRM: validity period required by CI]]** from the submission date.

Annex A: Curricula vitae

[[TO CONFIRM: CVs for each named team member, two pages each, covering qualifications, years of experience, sector experience, Africa experience and the three most relevant assignments. Criterion 3.1 carries 15 points and is scored on this annex.]]

Annex B: Client references

	Organisation	Contact	Assignment referenced
Reference 1	[[TO CONFIRM]]	[[TO CONFIRM]]	[[TO CONFIRM]]
Reference 2	[[TO CONFIRM]]	[[TO CONFIRM]]	[[TO CONFIRM]]
Reference 3	[[TO CONFIRM]]	[[TO CONFIRM]]	[[TO CONFIRM]]

[[TO CONFIRM: full reference detail including contact email and telephone, the assignment referenced and recorded consent to be contacted. Owner: EY bid team.]]

Annex C: Capability against the eight required skills, and relevant assignments

The RFP sets these eight as minimum requirements for all offerors. The middle column states what would actually satisfy a CI evaluator, so that the evidence gathered answers the question asked rather than the question a capability statement usually answers.

Required skill	What satisfies an evaluator	To be supplied
Proven knowledge and experience in brand development, destination branding	Hardest of the eight for a Big Four consulting practice. What satisfies an evaluator is two or three assignments where the deliverable was a brand strategy, brand architecture or destination positioning for a place rather than a company, each with client, country, year and EY's role, plus a named individual whose CV carries the phrase destination branding. Customer, marketing or design-studio credentials from within the firm can support this but will not carry it alone. If there is nothing in the last five years, the honest and higher-scoring answer is a named specialist partner or subcontractor with their own track record, which the RFP expressly permits.	[[TO CONFIRM: two to three brand strategy or destination brand assignments, with client, country, year, EY's role and the outcome – or, if EY holds none in the last five years, the named destination-branding partner or subcontractor carrying this skill, with two comparable assignments of its own. Supplied by Michael Harris. This is a stated minimum requirement, so leaving it unevidenced risks responsiveness, not just points.]]
Skills and experience in business planning, development of business models, financial modelling	The easiest of the eight and the one EY should lead with. What satisfies is two or three assignments where EY designed a business model or built a financial model that supported a real decision, with client, year, the decision taken and the scale involved. At least one should be for a not-for-profit, public or donor-funded entity, because the CI problem is sustainability under a declining grant rather than shareholder value.	[[TO CONFIRM: two to three business model design or financial modelling assignments, with client, year, the decision the work supported and its scale; at least one for a not-for-profit, public body or donor-funded entity. Supplied by the EY bid team.]]
Global exposure and experience in tourism and leading brand development and management	Partly evidenced. The global-network half is straightforward for a Big Four firm: the tourism, hospitality and leisure sector group, its named leader, the countries it covers, and two non-African tourism assignments from the last five years. The 'leading brand development and management' half is not, and should not be over-claimed; it belongs with the destination branding adviser. Split the row in the proposal rather than blurring the two halves into one confident sentence.	[[TO CONFIRM: EY global tourism, hospitality and leisure sector credentials — the network or sector group drawn on for this engagement, its named leader, and two non-African tourism assignments from the last five years with client, country and year. Supplied by the EY bid team.]]

Required skill	What satisfies an evaluator	To be supplied
Proven ability to work with the private sector and secure investment or funding	Well within reach. What satisfies is two or three assignments where EY structured, raised or helped secure private, blended or concessional capital, each naming the instrument and the amount raised or committed. One conservation-finance, natural-capital or development-finance example lifts this row from generically strong to directly relevant, and is the bridge to the conservation skill below.	[[TO CONFIRM: two to three assignments where EY structured, raised or secured private or blended capital, with client, year, instrument and amount raised or committed; include a conservation, natural capital or development finance example if one exists. Supplied by the EY bid team.]]
Presentation of business cases and pitching	Easy, and under-evidenced if left as an assertion. What satisfies is two named examples of business cases EY prepared and then presented to an investment committee, a board or a donor, with the decision that followed. This skill also matters operationally, since deliverable 3 is a presentation to stakeholder groups, so tie the examples to the named individuals who will actually present in week 10.	[[TO CONFIRM: two examples of business cases EY prepared and presented to an investment committee, board or donor, with the audience, the year and the decision taken; identify which named team member presented. Supplied by the EY bid team.]]
Stakeholder management and partnerships	Easy. What satisfies is one or two multi-stakeholder or multi-government assignments, stating how many stakeholder groups were engaged, of what type, and how alignment was actually reached. Relevance beats scale: a cross-border or cross-ministry study is worth more here than a large single-client transformation.	[[TO CONFIRM: one to two multi-stakeholder or multi-government assignments, with client, year, the number and type of stakeholder groups engaged and how alignment was reached. Supplied by the EY bid team.]]
Experience of the Africa region and tourism landscape	Half easy, half not. The Africa half is a natural Big Four strength and is evidenced by the member-firm footprint, country by country, with entity, office and consulting headcount. The tourism-landscape half needs actual tourism, hospitality or destination assignments in African countries, with country, client and year. Keep the two claims separate; a footprint map presented as sector experience is transparent to an evaluator.	[[TO CONFIRM: EY Africa tourism, hospitality or destination assignments with country, client, year and scope; and, separately, the EY Africa member-firm footprint in the countries holding CI's priority areas. Supplied by the EY Africa markets team.]]
Experience in protected areas and conservation	Alongside destination branding, the least natural fit for a Big Four practice and the strongest argument for a consortium. What satisfies is any assignment in protected areas, conservation finance, natural capital, biodiversity or park-adjacent tourism, with client, year and scope. If nothing releasable exists, the named conservation specialist or consortium partner and their protected-area track record is the answer, and it should be stated plainly rather than papered over with sustainability or ESG credentials, which an evaluator at Conservation International will recognise as a different thing.	[[TO CONFIRM: any EY assignment in protected areas, conservation finance, natural capital, biodiversity or park-adjacent tourism, with client, year and scope; if none is releasable, the named conservation specialist or consortium partner supplying this skill, with their protected-area track record. Supplied by Michael Harris. Do not substitute general ESG or sustainability credentials, which a CI evaluator will read as a different capability.]]

Relevant assignments, last five years

[[TO CONFIRM: assignment sheets covering the last five years, each with client, year, value, scope and outcome. Criterion 2.2 asks for the last three years with samples, while Part 1 asks for the last five, so the annex is built to satisfy both windows. At least three entries from the last three years must carry a released sample. Owner: EY bid team.]]

Annex D: Detailed work plan

[[TO CONFIRM: expanded week-by-week plan with named owners, once the team at section 6 is confirmed.]]

Annex E: Compliance matrix

The full matrix is maintained at qa/compliance_matrix.md in the working files and is reproduced here at submission.

Annex F: Benchmark scan, archetype map and rating matrix

Extract from EY's pre-bid benchmark scan of 31 brands, networks and mechanisms, described at section 2. Figures are as published by each source and accessed September 2026. They have not yet been verified with the organisations concerned, and verification is the first task of Activity One.

F.1 Seven archetypes along CI's solution spectrum

Archetype and sub-types	What the centre does	Members and payers	Where it sits against CI's brief	Benchmarks in this pass
1. Shared service In-house service unit; conservancy association; coaching network	Provides back-office capability many sites draw on: design systems, monitoring, coaching, governance and enterprise support.	Members: sites, landholders or businesses. Payers: donors, governments or member fees.	CI's 'simple version': a technical assistance retainer parks draw down on	NPS Harpers Ferry Center; NRT; NACSO (new); MMWCA (new); The Long Run
2. Site standard Global owner with national operators; national scheme	Certifies places against criteria, verifies them and runs a peer network; sites earn, and can lose, the right to the mark.	Members: protected areas, destinations, beaches. Payers: sites, their authorities and national operators.	Middle ground: brand credibility without a consumer-facing company	EUROPARC Charter (ECST); UNESCO Global Geoparks; Slovenia Green; Blue Flag (new)
3. Enterprise mark (new) Business standard; product mark	Certifies businesses or products whose practices benefit people and wildlife, and opens trade channels for them.	Members: lodges, operators, producers. Payers: certified businesses, tour operators and donors.	Carries a park's story to the businesses and products around it; supports CI's merchandise stream	Fair Trade Tourism (new); Certified Wildlife Friendly (new)
4. Place marketer Publicly hosted brand; member-funded club of places; national brand buying reach	Markets a shared place identity across sites or borders to trade and consumers.	Members: governments, destinations or businesses. Payers: governments and donors, or the members.	Tests how any model reconciles with national destination brands	Boundless Southern Africa; KAZA 'Rivers of Life'; Africa's Eden Tourism; World Heritage Journeys; EDEN; Alpine Pearls (new); Visit Rwanda (new)
5. Curator and distributor Independent consortium; hosted or borrowed-brand collection; tourism-board collectives; low-cost regional curation	Selects members against criteria, then sells them through one brand, trade network, loyalty scheme and booking channels.	Members: hotels, lodges, experience businesses. Payers: members, through fees and commissions.	CI's 'complex version': the LHW-style platform, or a collection hosted on an existing one	LHW; Relais & Châteaux; SLH (new); Beyond Green (new); National Geographic Unique Lodges; Signature Experiences of Australia; Experience Mekong Collection
6. Portfolio umbrella Manager or owner of many sites	Manages or owns many sites and carries an institutional brand above the site brands.	Sites sit inside the portfolio. Payers: donors, visitors and members.	Brand architecture lessons; potential delivery partners	African Parks; National Trust; Rewilding Europe
7. Revenue engine Consumer pass or membership; matched public funds; corporate levy or licence	A monetisation mechanism that can bolt onto any model.	Payers: visitors, industry or corporate brands.	Maps to CI's named streams: wild cards, memberships, sponsorship	SANParks Wild Card; Brand USA match; The Lion's Share Fund

F.2 Three design choices that cut across the archetypes

Design choice	Options seen in the benchmarks	What it means for CI
Who belongs and pays	Sites or landholders: NRT, NACSO, MMWCA, Alpine Pearls, Geoparks. Businesses: LHW, SLH, Beyond Green, Africa's Eden Tourism, The Long Run. Visitors: SANParks Wild Card, National Trust. Corporates: The Lion's Share Fund.	Park authorities are the obvious members but the weakest payers. Lodges, operators and visitors hold the money; the model must decide whom it serves first.
How it crosses borders	One regional secretariat: Boundless Southern Africa, KAZA. National operators under a global owner: Blue Flag, ECST national sections. Mutual recognition of national schemes: Fair Trade Tourism. A cross-border legal vehicle: Alpine Pearls, an EGTC since 2022. A global company: LHW, SLH, Preferred Hotel Group.	CI's 15 areas span Southern, Eastern and Western Africa. National operators and mutual recognition have scaled further than single secretariats in this set.
How it relates to the national brand	Owned by the tourism board: Slovenia Green, Signature Experiences of Australia, Visit Rwanda. Co-brand hub: KAZA 'Rivers of Life'. Independent: LHW, National Geographic Unique Lodges, The Long Run.	Board ownership aligns incentives but ties the model to public budgets. A co-brand hub leaves the board in charge of the national story while the parks supply proof.

F.3 Initial read against CI's design aims

H strong evidence **M** partial **L** weak or absent **?** not yet evidenced **n/a** not applicable. Ratings are team judgement on the desk evidence gathered in this pass and will move as the deep-dives land.

Benchmark	Self-funding	Aggregation	Conservation-led	Data	Segments and appeal	National brand fit	Cross-border	Low-capacity fit	African evidence
Shared service									
Northern Rangelands Trust	L	H	H	M	L	n/a	M	H	H
NACSO NEW	L	H	H	H	L	M	L	H	H
MMWCA NEW	?	H	H	M	M	?	L	H	H
NPS Harpers Ferry Center	L	H	M	L	L	H	L	H	L
The Long Run	?	M	H	H	L	n/a	H	M	H
Site standard									
EUROPARC Charter (ECST)	M	M	H	M	L	M	H	M	L
UNESCO Global Geoparks	M	M	H	M	M	M	H	L	L
Slovenia Green	M	H	H	H	M	H	L	H	L
Blue Flag NEW	M	H	M	H	L	M	H	M	M
Enterprise mark									
Fair Trade Tourism NEW	L	M	M	M	L	M	H	H	H

Benchmark	Self-funding	Aggregation	Conservation-led	Data	Segments and appeal	National brand fit	Cross-border	Low-capacity fit	African evidence
Certified Wildlife Friendly NEW	?	M	H	M	L	n/a	H	H	M
Place marketer									
Boundless Southern Africa	L	M	M	?	M	M	H	M	H
KAZA 'Rivers of Life'	L	M	H	M	?	M	H	M	H
Africa's Eden Tourism	H	M	M	?	?	?	H	M	H
Alpine Pearls NEW	M	H	M	?	M	M	H	M	L
World Heritage Journeys	L	H	M	M	H	M	H	M	L
EDEN	L	M	M	L	M	H	H	H	L
Visit Rwanda NEW	L	M	M	M	M	H	L	M	H
Curator and distributor									
LHW	H	H	L	H	M	L	H	L	?
Relais & Châteaux	H	H	M	H	M	L	H	L	M
SLH NEW	H	H	M	M	H	L	H	L	?
Beyond Green NEW	H	H	H	M	L	L	H	L	H
National Geographic Unique Lodges	H	M	H	M	L	L	H	L	H
Signature Experiences of Australia	M	H	M	M	H	H	L	M	L
Experience Mekong Collection	L	H	M	L	M	M	H	H	L
Portfolio umbrella									
African Parks	L	H	H	H	M	M	M	H	H
National Trust	H	H	H	H	H	M	L	H	L
Rewilding Europe	M	M	H	M	M	L	H	M	L
Revenue engine									

Benchmark	Self-funding	Aggregation	Conservation-led	Data	Segments and appeal	National brand fit	Cross-border	Low-capacity fit	African evidence
SANParks Wild Card	H	H	M	M	M	M	M	M	H
Brand USA	M	H	L	H	H	H	L	?	L
The Lion's Share Fund	M	M	H	L	L	n/a	H	?	?

F.4 The thirteen deep-dives Activity One will fund

Eight case studies, two of them clustered, and five light-touch checks. This is what the published budget will carry over twelve desk-based weeks.

Benchmark	Tier	Why it earns a deep-dive
Boundless Southern Africa	1	Named by CI; the longest-running African transfrontier brand, publicly hosted since 2007.
Africa's Eden Tourism	1	Named by CI; the only African cross-border identity the private sector pays for.
KAZA 'Rivers of Life' and UniVisa	1	The newest African co-brand, designed for operators to adopt.
African conservancy associations: NRT, NACSO and MMWCA	1	The aggregation layer that already exists in CI's target geography; CI co-created the Maasai Mara Rescue Fund with MMWCA.
The Long Run	1	Coaching-plus-standard pathway with strong African membership.
Slovenia Green	1	A national tourism board owns the label.
Signature Experiences of Australia	1	Collectives backed by a national tourism organisation, at a scale close to CI's 15 areas.
Commercial collectives: LHW and Relais & Châteaux, with SLH, Beyond Green and National Geographic Unique Lodges	1	CI's named commercial reference, and the build, host or borrow choice.
SANParks Wild Card	2	African proof of a multi-agency pass.
Site standards: UNESCO Global Geoparks, ECST and Blue Flag	2	Quality assurance with consequences, and delivery through national operators.
Enterprise marks: Fair Trade Tourism and Certified Wildlife Friendly	2	An African-led business mark and a mark that travels onto products.
Alpine Pearls	2	A club of places across borders, with a legal vehicle.
Visit Rwanda	2	A national brand spending heavily on reach.